

THE ART OF DEALING WITH TRUMP 2.0

TRUMP IS AN IDEA WHOSE TIME HAS COME

MIKE POMPEO

Former US Secretary of State (2018-2021); former Director, CIA (2017-2018)

Former US Secretary of State Mike Pompeo believes that Donald Trump's second term is largely a continuation of his first, the key difference being that Trump is now more prepared. While the first 50 days of Trump 2.0 have been full of "noise", Pompeo sees in them not flux but the enduring of consistent Trumpian themes. At the India Today Conclave, as he offered insightful commentary on global institutions, US foreign policy and the shifting geopolitical landscape, the only drastic departure from the past Pompeo presented was in his own dramatic physical transformation—the former CIA director appeared leaner, reportedly having lost 90 pounds in six months.

Discussing the Russia-Ukraine war, Pompeo acknowledged that the confrontation between Trump and Ukrainian president Volodymyr Zelensky at the White House was "unfortunate", but assured it would not impact US policy on Ukraine. He reiterated Trump's long-standing stance that Europe must take greater responsibility for its own security, rather than relying on US military and economic support. "The President has been clear: we need Europeans to invest, to stop buying Russian natural gas—these were the things he spoke about throughout his campaign," Pompeo remarked.

"Don't listen to the noise, don't listen to the soundbite, don't follow tweet by tweet. Look at the things the Trump administration does and delivers"

"I think the meeting with President Zelensky... was very unfortunate. But it's not going to change much in terms of how the US is going to interact with the conflict in Ukraine"

"Global multilateral institutions are broken, they no longer serve their purpose. They've walked away from their charters, and are dominated by the Chinese Communist Party"

He justified Trump's decision to withdraw funding from bodies like the World Health Organization and the UN Human Rights Council, stating that they had strayed from their original purpose. He argued that multilateral organisations like the United Nations—once pillars of global stability—are ineffective and "broken" and influenced by the Chinese Communist Party. He stressed that Trump was not abandoning multilateralism but rather redefining it through alternative alliances like the Abraham Accords and the Quad alliance as a counter to growing Chinese aggression.

On asked why illegal Indian immigrants to the US, while being deported back, were handcuffed, shackled and videographed, Pompeo asserted that they were "all convicted criminals who were in American jails". He said deportation of illegal immigrants was needed to protect American sovereignty and that Trump had done more in this regard "in 20 days" than had happened in the term of his predecessor Joe Biden.

The former secretary of state replied in the affirmative when asked if the US would honour its promise to come to the military aid of Taiwan if it faced aggression from China, though